

VOLUME TWO

SUBJECTIVE LOGIC or THE DOCTRINE OF THE NOTION

...

First we saw subjectivity, the Notion's *being-for-self*, pass over into its *in-itself*, *objectivity*, to be followed by the reappearance in the latter of the negativity of the Notion's being-for-self; in that negativity the Notion has determined itself in such a manner that its *particularity* is an *external objectivity*, or it has determined itself as a simple concrete unity whose externality is its self-determination. **The movement of the end has now reached the stage where the moment of externality is not merely posited in the Notion, where the end is not merely an *ought-to-be* and a *striving* to realize itself, but as a concrete totality is identical with the immediate objectivity. This identity is on the one hand the simple Notion and the equally *immediate* objectivity, but on the other hand, it is just as essentially a *mediation*, and only through the latter as a self-sublating mediation is it that simple immediacy;**

754

the Notion is therefore essentially this: to be distinct as an explicit identity from its *implicit* objectivity, and thereby to possess externality, yet in this external totality to be the totality's self-determining identity. As such, the Notion is now the *Idea*.

Section Three: The Idea

The Idea is the *adequate Notion*, that which is objectively *true*, or the *true as such*. When anything whatever possesses truth, it possesses it through its Idea, or, *something possesses truth only in so far as it is Idea*. The expression 'idea' has often been employed in philosophy as in ordinary life for 'notion', indeed, even for a mere ordinary conception: 'I have no *idea* yet of this lawsuit, building, neighbourhood', means nothing more than the ordinary conception. **Kant has reclaimed the expression Idea for the *notion of reason*.** Now according to Kant, the notion of reason is supposed to be the notion of the *unconditioned*, but a notion *transcendent* in regard to phenomena, that is, no *empirical use* can be made of such notion that is *adequate to it*. The notions of reason are to serve for the comprehension of perceptions, the notions of the understanding for understanding them. But in fact, **if the latter really are *Notions*, then they are *Notions-they enable one to comprehend (begreifen)*, and an *understanding* of perceptions by means of notions of the understanding will be a *comprehension* of them.** But if understanding is

only a determining of perceptions by such categories as for example whole and parts, force, cause, and the like, it signifies only a determining by reflection; and similarly, by understanding can be meant only the specific *representation* of a completely determined sensuous content; thus when someone, having been directed that at the end of the wood he must turn left, replies 'I *understand*', *understanding* means nothing more than the grasping of something in pictorial thought and in memory. '***Notion of reason***', too, is a somewhat clumsy expression; for the Notion is something altogether rational; and **in so far as reason is distinguished from understanding and the Notion as such, it is the totality of the Notion and of objectivity. In this sense the Idea is the *rational***; it is the unconditioned, because only that has conditions which essentially relates itself to an objectivity, but an objectivity that it has not itself determined but which still confronts it in the form of indifference and externality, just as the external end still had conditions. Reserving then the expression 'Idea' for the objective or real Notion and distinguishing it from the Notion itself and still more from mere pictorial thought, we must also reject even more vigor

756

ously that estimate of the Idea according to which it is not anything actual, and true thoughts are said to be *only ideas*. If *thoughts* are merely *subjective* and contingent, they certainly have no further value; but in this respect they are not inferior to temporal and contingent *actualities* which likewise have no further value than that of contingencies and phenomena. On the other hand if, conversely, the Idea is not to have the value of truth, because in regard to phenomena it is *transcendent*, and no congruent object can be assigned to it in the world of sense, this is an odd misunderstanding that would deny objective validity to the Idea because it lacks that which constitutes Appearance, namely, the *untrue being* of the objective world. In regard to practical Ideas, Kant recognizes that 'nothing can be more harmful and unworthy of a philosopher than the *vulgar* appeal to an *experience* that allegedly conflicts with the Idea. This very experience would not even exist if, for example, political institutions had been established at the proper time in conformity with Ideas, and if *crude conceptions*, crude just because they had been drawn from experience, had not taken the place of Ideas and so nullified every good intention.' Kant regards the Idea as a necessity and as the goal which, as the *archetype*, it must be our endeavour to set up for a maximum and to which we must strive to bring the condition of the actual world ever nearer .

But having reached the result that **the Idea is the unity of the Notion and objectivity**, is the true, it must not be regarded merely as a *goal* to which we have to approximate but which itself always remains a kind of *beyond*; on the contrary, we must recognize that **everything actual is only in so far as it possesses the Idea and expresses it**. It is not merely that the object, the objective and subjective world in general, *ought to be congruous* with the Idea, but they are themselves the congruence of Notion and reality; **the reality that does not correspond to the Notion is mere *Appearance*, the**

subjective, contingent, capricious element that is not the truth. When it is said that no object is to be found in experience that is perfectly congruous with the *Idea*, one is opposing the Idea as a subjective standard to the actual; but what anything actual is supposed in truth *to be*, if its Notion is not in it and if its objectivity does not correspond to its Notion at all, it is impossible to say; for it would be nothing. It is true that the mechanical and chemical object, like the non-spiritual subject and the spirit that is conscious

757 only of the finite, not of its essence, do not, according to their various natures, have their Notion existent in them *in its own free form*. **But they can only be true at all in so far as they are the union of their Notion and reality, of their soul and their body.** Wholes like the state and the church cease to exist when the unity of their Notion and their reality is dissolved; man, the living being, is dead when soul and body are parted in him; dead nature, the mechanical and chemical world-taking, that is, the dead world to mean the inorganic world, otherwise it would have no positive meaning at all-**dead nature, then, if it is separated into its Notion and its reality, is nothing but the subjective abstraction of a thought form and a formless matter. *Spirit* that was not Idea, was not the unity of the Notion with its own self, or the Notion that did not have the Notion itself for its reality would be dead, spiritless spirit, a material object.**

The Idea being the unity of Notion and reality, *being* has attained the significance of *truth*; therefore what now *is* is only what is Idea. Finite things are finite because they do not possess the complete reality of their Notion within themselves, but require other things to complete it-or, conversely, because they are presupposed as objects, hence possess the Notion as an external determination. The highest to which they attain on the side of this finitude is external purposiveness. That actual things are not congruous with the Idea is the side of their *finitude* and *untruth*, and in accordance with this side they are *objects*, determined in accordance with their various spheres and in the relationships of objectivity, either mechanically, chemically or by an external end. That the Idea has not completely leavened its reality, has imperfectly subdued it to the Notion, this is a possibility arising from the fact that the Idea itself has a *restricted content*, that though it is essentially the unity of Notion and reality, it is no less essentially their difference; for only the object is their immediate, that is, merely *implicit* unity. But if an object, for example the state, *did not correspond at all* to its Idea, that is, if in fact it was not the Idea of the state at all, if its reality, which is the self-conscious individuals, did not correspond at all to the Notion, its soul and its body would have parted; the former would escape into the solitary regions of thought, the latter would have broken up into the single individualities. But because the Notion of the state so essentially constitutes the nature of these individualities, it is present in them

as an urge so powerful that they are impelled to translate it into reality, be it only in the form of external purposiveness, or to put up with it as it is, or else they must needs perish. The worst state, one whose reality least corresponds to the Notion, in so far as it still exists, is still Idea i the individuals still obey a dominant Notion.

However, the Idea has not merely the more general meaning of the *true being*, of the unity of *Notion* and *reality*, but the more specific one of **the unity of subjective Notion and objectivity**. That is to say, the Notion as such is itself already the identity of itself and *reality*, **for the indefinite expression 'reality' means in general nothing else but determinate being**, and this the Notion possesses in its particularity and individuality. Similarly too, *objectivity* is the total *Notion* that out of its determinateness has withdrawn into *identity* with itself. In the former subjectivity the determinateness or difference of the Notion is an *illusory being* (*Schein*) that is immediately sublated and has withdrawn into being-for-self or negative unity. It is an *inhering* predicate. But in this objectivity the determinateness is posited as an immediate totality, as an external whole. **Now the Idea has shown itself to be the Notion liberated again into its subjectivity from the immediacy in which it is submerged in the object**; to be the Notion that distinguishes itself from its objectivity, which however is no less determined by it and possesses its substantiality only in that Notion. **This identity has therefore rightly been defined as the subject-object**, for it is as well the formal or subjective Notion as it is the object as such. But this must be understood more precisely. The Notion, having truly attained its reality, is this absolute judgement whose *subject*, as self-related negative unity, distinguishes itself from its objectivity and is the latter's being-in-and-for-self, but essentially relates itself to it through itself. It is therefore its *own end* (*Selbstzweck*) and the *urge* to realize it; but for this very reason the subject does not possess objectivity in an immediate manner, for if it did it would be merely the totality of the object as such lost in objectivity; on the contrary, objectivity is the realization of the end, an objectivity *posited* by the activity of the end, an objectivity which, as *positedness*, possesses its subsistence and its form only as permeated by its subject. As objectivity, it has in it the moment of the *externality* of the Notion and is therefore in general the side of finitude, change and Appearance, a side, however, which meets

with extinction in its retraction into the negative unity of the Notion; the negativity whereby its indifferent mutual externality exhibits itself as unessential and a positivity, is the Notion itself. The Idea is, therefore, in spite of this objectivity utterly *simple* and *immaterial*, for the externality exists only as determined by the Notion and as taken up into its negative unity; in so far as it exists as indifferent externality it is not merely at the

mercy of mechanism in general but exists only as the transitory and untrue. Although therefore the Idea has its reality in a material externality. this is not an abstract *being* subsisting on its own account over against the Notion ; on the contrary. it exists only as a *becoming* through the negativity of indifferent being. as a simple determinateness of the Notion.

This yields the following more precise definitions of the Idea. First. it is the simple truth. the identity of the Notion and objectivity as *a universal* in which the opposition and subsistence of the particular is dissolved into its self-identical negativity and is equality with itself. Secondly. it is the *relation* of the explicit subjectivity of the simple Notion and its objectivity which is *distinguished* therefrom; the former is essentially the *urge* to sublimate this separation. and the latter is the indifferent positedness. the subsistence that is in and for itself null. As this relation. the Idea is the *process* of sundering itself into individuality and its inorganic nature. and again of bringing this inorganic nature under the power of the subject and returning to the first simple universality. **The identity of the Idea with itself is one with the process**; the thought which liberates actuality from the illusory show of purposeless mutability and transfigures it into the Idea must not represent this truth of actuality as a dead repose, as a mere *picture*, lifeless, without impulse or movement, as a genius or number, or an abstract thought; by virtue of the freedom which the Notion attains in the Idea, the Idea possesses within itself also the *most stubborn opposition*; its repose consists in the security and certainty with which it eternally creates and eternally overcomes that opposition, in it meeting with *itself*. In the first instance, however, the Idea is once again only *immediate* or only in its *Notion*; objective reality is, it is true, conformable to the Notion, but it is not yet liberated into the Notion, and the latter does not exist explicitly *for itself as Notion*. Thus though the Notion is *soul*, it is soul in the guise of an

760

immediate, that is, its determinateness does not appear *as* soul itself, it has not grasped itself as soul, it does not possess its objective reality within itself; the Notion is as a soul that is not yet *fully a soul*.

At this first stage the Idea is *Life*: the Notion that, distinguished from its objectivity, simple within itself, pervades its objectivity and, as its own end, possesses its means in the objectivity and posits the latter as its means, yet is immanent in this means and is therein the realized end that is identical with itself. This Idea, on account of its immediacy, has *individuality* for the form of its existence. But the reflection-into-self of its absolute process is the sublating of this immediate individuality ; thereby the Notion

which, as universality in this individuality, is the *inwardness* of the latter, converts the externality into universality, or posits its objectivity as being the same as itself.

In this second stage, the Idea is the Idea of the *true* and the *good*, as *cognition* and *volition*. In the first instance, it is finite cognition and finite volition, in which the true and the good are still distinguished and each appears as yet only as a *goal*. The Notion has, in the first instance, liberated *itself* into itself and as yet given itself only an *abstract objectivity* for its reality. But the process of this finite cognition and action converts the initially abstract universality into a totality, whereby it becomes a *complete objectivity*. Or, to consider it from the other side, finite, that is, subjective spirit, *makes for itself the presupposition of an objective world*, just as life *has* such a presupposition; but its activity consists in sublating this presupposition and converting it into a positedness. In this way its reality is for it the objective world, or conversely, the objective world is the ideality in which it cognizes itself.

Thirdly, spirit cognizes the Idea as its *absolute truth*, as the truth that is in and for itself; the infinite Idea in which cognition and action are equalized, and which is the *absolute knowledge of itself*.

...

In synthetic cognition, therefore, the Idea attains its end only to the extent that the *Notion* becomes *for the Notion* according to its *moments of identity and real determinations*, or of *universality and particular differences-further also as an identity that is the connexion and dependence of the diverse elements*. But this subject matter of the Notion is not adequate to it; for the Notion does not come to be the *unity of itself with itself in its subject matter or its reality*; in necessity its identity is for it; but in this identity the necessity is not itself the *determinateness*, but appears as a matter external to the identity, that is, as a matter not determined by the Notion, a matter, therefore, in which the Notion does not cognize itself. Thus in general the Notion is not for itself, is not at the same time determined in and for itself according to its unity. Hence in this cognition the Idea still falls short of truth on account of the inadequacy of the subject matter to the subjective Notion. But **the sphere of necessity is the apex of being and reflection; through its own essential nature [*an und fur sich selbst*] it passes over into the freedom of the Notion, inner identity passes over into its manifestation, which is the Notion as Notion. **How this transition from the sphere of necessity into the Notion is effected in principle [*an sich*]** has been shown in treating of necessity; the same transition also presented itself as the *genesis of the Notion* at the beginning of this**

book. Here *necessity* has the position of being the *reality* or *subject matter* of the Notion, just as the Notion into which it passes now appears as the Notion's subject matter. But the transition itself is the same. Here too it is only at first *implicit* and lies as yet outside cognition in our reflection; that is, it is still the inner necessity of the cognition itself. It is only the result that is for it. The Idea, in so far as the Notion is now *explicitly* determined in and for itself, is the *practical* Idea, or *action*.

B. THE IDEA OF THE GOOD

The Notion, which is its own subject matter, being determined in and for itself, the subject is determined for itself as an *individual*. As subjective it again presupposes an implicit otherness; it is the *urge* to realize itself, the end that wills *by means of itself* to give itself objectivity and to realize itself in the objective world. In the theoretical Idea the subjective Notion, as the *universal* that *lacks any determination* of its own, stands opposed to the objective world from which it takes to itself a determinate content and filling. But in the practical Idea it is as actual that it confronts the actual ; but the certainty of itself which the subject possesses in being determined in and for itself is a certainty of its own actuality and of the *non-actuality* of the world; it is not only the world's otherness as an abstract universality that is a nullity for the subject, but the world's individuality and the determinations of its individuality. The subject has here vindicated *objectivity* for itself; its immanent determinateness is the objective, for **it is the universality that is just as much absolutely determined**; the formerly objective world, on the contrary , is now only something posited, something *immediately* determined in various ways, but because it is only immediately determined, the unity of the Notion is lacking in it and it is, by itself, a nullity.

This determinateness contained in the Notion and in the likeness of the Notion, and including within it the demand for an individual external actuality, is the *good*. It comes upon the scene with the worth of being absolute, because it is within itself the totality of the Notion, the objective that is at the same time in the form of free unity and subjectivity. This Idea is superior to the Idea of cognition already considered, for it possesses not only the worth

of the universal but also of the out-and-out actual. It is an *urge* in so far as this actuality is still subjective, positing its own self, and not having at the same time the form of immediate presupposition ; its urge to realize itself is, strictly speaking, not to give itself

objectivity-this it possesses within itself-but merely this empty form of immediacy. Hence the activity of the end is not directed against itself in order to adopt and appropriate a given determination; on the contrary, it is in order to posit its own determination and by sublating the determinations of the external world to give itself reality in the form of external actuality. The Idea of the will as *explicitly* self-determining possesses the *content* within itself. Now it is true that this is a *determinate* content and to that extent something *finite* and *limited*; self-determination is essentially *particularization*, since the reflection of the will into itself as a negative unity in general is also individuality in the sense of the exclusion and presupposition of an other. Nevertheless, the particularity of the content is in the first instance infinite through the form of the Notion, whose own determinateness it is; and in this content the Notion possesses its negative self-identity, and therefore not merely a particular, but its own infinite individuality. Consequently the above-mentioned *finitude* of the content in the practical Idea is tantamount to the latter being in the first instance the not yet realized Idea; the Notion is, *for the content*, something that is in and for itself; it is here the Idea in the form of objectivity that is *for itself*; on the one hand, the subjective is for this reason no longer something merely *posited*, arbitrary or contingent, but an absolute; but on the other hand, *this form of concrete existence, being-for-self*, has not as yet the form of the *in-itself* as well. What thus appears in respect of form as such, as opposition, appears in the form of the Notion reflected into *simple identity*, that is, appears in the content as its simple determinateness; thus the good, although valid in and for itself, is some particular end, but an end that has not to wait to receive its truth through its realization, but is already on its own account the true.

The syllogism of immediate *realization* itself requires no detailed exposition here; it is altogether the same as the syllogism of *external purposiveness* considered above; it is only the content that constitutes the difference. In external as in formal purposiveness, it was an indeterminate finite content in general; here, though it is finite too, it is as such at the same time an absolutely

822

hence posited *for the objective Notion*. Now just as in the end relation in general, the realized end is also again merely a means, while conversely the means is also the realized end, so similarly in the syllogism of the good, the second premiss is immediately already present *implicitly* in the first; but this immediacy is not sufficient, and the second premiss is already postulated for the first-the realization of the good in the face of another actuality confronting it is the mediation which is essentially necessary for the immediate relation and the accomplished actualization of the good. For it is only the first negation or the otherness of the Notion, an objectivity that would be a submergence of the Notion in the externality; the second negation is the sublating of this otherness, whereby the immediate realization of the end first becomes the actuality of the good as of the Notion

that is for itself, since in this actuality the Notion is posited as identical with itself, not with an other, and thus alone is posited as the free Notion. Now if it is supposed that the end of the good is after all not realized through this mediation, this signifies a relapse of the Notion to the standpoint occupied by it before its activity-the standpoint of an actuality determined as worthless and yet presupposed as real. This relapse, which becomes the progress to the spurious infinity, has its sole ground in the fact that in the sublation of that abstract reality this sublation is no less immediately forgotten, or it is forgotten that this reality is in fact already presupposed as an actuality that is intrinsically worthless and not objective. This repetition of the presupposition of the unrealized end after the actual realization of the end consequently assumes this character, that the *subjective bearing* of the objective Notion is reproduced and made perpetual, with the result that the *finitude* of the good in respect of its content as well as its form appears as the abiding truth, and its actualization appears always as a merely *individual* act, and not as a universal one. As a matter of fact this determinateness has sublated itself in the actualization of the good; what still *limits* the objective Notion is its own *view* of itself, which vanishes by reflection on what its actualization is *in itself*. Through this view it is only standing in its own way, and thus what it has to do is to turn, not against an outer actuality, but against itself.

In other words, the activity in the second premiss produces only a one-sided *being-for-self*, and its product therefore appears as something *subjective* and *individual*, and consequently the first

823

presupposition is repeated in it. But this activity is in truth no less the positing of the *implicit* identity of the objective Notion and the immediate actuality. This latter is determined by the presupposition as having a phenomenal reality only, as being intrinsically worthless and simply and solely determinable by the objective Notion. When external actuality is altered by the activity of the objective Notion and its determination therewith sublated, by that very fact the merely phenomenal reality, the external determinability and worthlessness, are removed from that actuality and it is *posited* as being in and for itself. In this process the general presupposition is sublated, namely the determination of the good as a merely subjective end limited in respect of content, the necessity of realizing it by subjective activity, and this activity itself. In the result the mediation sublates itself; the result is an *immediacy* that is not the restoration of the presupposition, but rather its accomplished sublation. With this, the Idea of the Notion that is determined in and for itself is posited as being no longer merely in the active subject but as equally an immediate actuality ; and conversely, this actuality is posited, as it is in cognition, as an objectivity possessing a true being. The individuality of the subject with which the subject was burdened by its presupposition, has vanished along with the presupposition ; hence the subject now exists as *free, universal self-identity*, for

which the objectivity of the Notion is a *given* objectivity *immediately to hand*, no less truly than the subject knows itself as the Notion that is determined in and for itself. Accordingly in this result *cognition* is restored and united with the practical Idea; the actuality found as given is at the same time determined as the realized absolute end; but whereas in questing cognition this actuality appeared merely as an objective world without the subjectivity of the Notion, here it appears as an objective world whose inner ground and actual subsistence is the Notion. This is the absolute Idea.

CHAPTER 3

THE ABSOLUTE IDEA

The absolute Idea has shown itself to be the identity of the theoretical and the practical Idea. Each of these by itself is still one-sided, possessing the Idea itself only as a sought-for beyond and an unattained goal; each, therefore, is a *synthesis of endeavour*, and has, but equally has *not*, the Idea in it; each passes from one thought to the other without bringing the two together, and so remains fixed in their contradiction. The absolute Idea, as the rational Notion that in its reality meets only with itself, is by virtue of this immediacy of its objective identity, on the one hand the return to *life*; but it has no less sublated this form of its immediacy, and contains within itself the highest degree of opposition. The Notion is not merely *soul*, but free subjective Notion that is for itself and therefore possesses *personality*-the practical, objective Notion determined in and for itself which, as person, is impenetrable atomic subjectivity-but which, none the less, is not exclusive individuality, but explicitly *universality* and *cognition*, and in its other has *its own* objectivity for its object. All else is error, confusion, opinion, endeavour, caprice and transitoriness; the absolute Idea alone is *being*, imperishable *life*, *self-knowing truth*, and is *all truth*.

It is the sole subject matter and content of philosophy. Since it contains *all* determinateness within it, and its essential nature is to return to itself through its self-determination or particularization, it has various shapes, and the business of philosophy is to cognize it in these. Nature and spirit are in general different modes of presenting *its existence*, art and religion its different modes of apprehending itself and giving itself an adequate existence. Philosophy has the same content and the same end as art and religion; but it is the highest mode of apprehending the absolute Idea, because its mode is the highest mode, the Notion. Hence it embraces those shapes of real and ideal finitude as well as of infinitude and holiness, and comprehends them and itself. The derivation and cognition of these particular modes is now the further business of the particular philosophical sciences. The

logical aspect of the absolute Idea may also be called a *mode* of it; but whereas *mode* signifies a *particular* kind, a *determinateness* of form, the logical aspect, on the contrary, is the universal mode in which all particular modes are sublated and enfolded. The logical Idea is the Idea itself in its pure essence, the Idea enclosed in simple identity within its Notion prior to its *immediate reflection* [*Scheinen*] in a form-determinateness. Hence logic exhibits the self-movement of the absolute Idea only as the original *word*, which is an *outwardizing* or *utterance* [*Ausserung*], but an utterance that in being has immediately vanished again as something outer [*Ausseres*]; the Idea is, therefore, only in this self-determination of *apprehending itself*; it is in *pure thought*, in which difference is not yet *otherness*, but is and remains perfectly transparent to itself. Thus the logical Idea has itself as the *infinite form* for its content form which constitutes the opposite to *content* to this extent that the content is the form-determination withdrawn into itself and sublated in the identity in such a manner that this concrete identity stands opposed to the identity explicated as form; the content has the shape of an other and a *datum* as against the form which as such stands simply in *relation*, and its determinateness is at the same time posited as an illueory being [*Schein*]. More exactly, the absolute Idea itself has for its content merely this, that the form determination is its own completed totality, the pure Notion. Now the determinateness of the Idea and the entire course followed by this determinateness has constituted the subject matter of the science of logic, from which course the absolute Idea itself has issued into *an existence of its own*; but the nature of this its existence has shown itself to be this, that determinateness does not have the shape of a *content*, but exists wholly as *form*, and that accordingly the Idea is the absolutely *universal Idea*. Therefore what remains to be considered here is not a content as such, but the universal aspect of its form—that is, the *method*.

Method may appear at first as the mere *manner* peculiar to the process of cognition, and as a matter of fact it has the nature of such. But the peculiar manner, as method, is not merely a modality of *being determined in and for itself*; it is a modality of cognition, and as such is posited as determined by the *Notion* and as form, in so far as the form is the soul of all objectivity and all otherwise determined content has its truth in the form alone. If the content again is assumed as given to the method and of a peculiar nature

826

of its own, then in such a determination method, as with the logical element in general, is a merely *external* form. Against this however we can appeal not only to the fundamental Notion of the science of logic; its entire course, in which all possible shapes of a given content and of objects came up for consideration, has demonstrated their transition and untruth; also that not merely was it impossible for a given object to be the foundation to which the absolute form stood in a merely external and contingent relationship but that, on the contrary, the absolute form has proved itself to be the absolute foundation and ultimate truth. From this course the method has emerged as the *self-knowing Notion* that

has itself, as the absolute, both subjective and objective, *for its subject matter*, consequently as the pure correspondence of the Notion and its reality, as a concrete existence that is the Notion itself.

Accordingly, what is to be considered here as method is only the movement of the *Notion* itself, the nature of which movement has already been cognized; but *first*, there is now the added *significance* that the *Notion is everything*, and its movement is the *universal absolute activity*, the self-determining and self-realizing movement. The method is therefore to be recognized as the unrestrictedly universal, internal and external mode; and as the absolutely infinite force, to which no object, presenting itself as something external, remote from and independent of reason, could offer resistance or be of a particular nature in opposition to it, or could not be penetrated by it. It is therefore *soul and substance*, and anything whatever is comprehended and known in its truth only when it is *completely subjugated to the method*; it is the method proper to every subject matter because its activity is the Notion. This is also the truer meaning if its *universality*; according to the universality of reflection it is regarded merely as the method for *everything*; but according to the universality of the Idea, it is both the manner peculiar to cognition, to the *subjectively* selfknowing Notion, and also the *objective* manner, or rather the *substantiality*, of *things-that* is of Notions, in so far as they appear primarily to *representation* and *reflection* as *others*. It is therefore not only the highest *force*, or rather the *sole* and absolute *force* of reason, but also its supreme and sole *urge* to find and cognize *itself by means of itself in everything*. Here, *secondly*, is indicated the *difference* of the *method from the Notion as such*, the *particular* aspect of the method. The Notion, when it was considered by

827

itself, appeared in its immediacy; the *reflection*, or *the Notion that considered it*, fell within *our* knowing. The method is this knowing itself, for which the Notion is not merely the subject matter, but knowing's own subjective act, the *instrument* and means of the cognizing activity, distinguished from that activity, but only as the activity's own essentiality. In the cognition of enquiry, the method likewise occupies the position of an *instrument*, of a means standing on the subjective side by which this side relates itself to the object. In this syllogism the subject is one extreme and the object the other, and the former by means of its method unites with the latter, but in doing so it does not *unite with itself*. The extremes remain diverse because subject, method, and object are not posited as *the one identical Notion*; the syllogism is therefore still the formal syllogism; the premiss in which the subject posits the form on its side as its method is an *immediate* determination, and therefore contains the determinations of form, as we have seen, of definition, division, and so forth, as facts *found existing in the subject*. In true cognition on the contrary, the method is not merely an aggregate of certain determinations, but the Notion that is determined in and for itself; and the Notion is the middle term only because

it has equally the significance of the objective, and consequently in the conclusion the objective does not merely attain an external determinateness by means of the method, but is posited in its identity with the subjective Notion.

I. Thus what constitute the method are the determinations of the Notion itself and their relations, which we have now to consider in their significance as determinations of the method. In doing so we must first begin with the *beginning*. Of the beginning we have already spoken at the beginning of the *Logic* itself, and also above, when dealing with subjective cognition, and we have shown that, if it is not made arbitrarily and with a categorical unconsciousness, it may indeed seem to involve a number of difficulties but nevertheless is of an extremely simple nature. Because it is the beginning, its content is an immediate, but an immediate that has the significance and form of *abstract universality*. Be it otherwise a content of *being*, or of *essence*, or of the *Notion*, it is as an immediate something *assumed, found already in existence, assertorical*. But first of all it is not an immediate of *sensuous intuition* or of *representation*, but of *thinking*, which on account of its immediacy may also be called a supersensuous

828

inner intuition. The immediate of sensuous intuition is a *manifold* and an *individual*. But cognition is thinking by means of notions, and therefore its beginning also is *only in the element of thought* it is a *simple* and a *universal*. This form has already been discussed under definition. At the beginning of finite cognition universality is likewise recognized as an essential determination, but it is taken as a determination of thought and of Notion only in opposition to being. In point of fact this *first* universality is an *immediate* one, and for that reason has equally the significance of *being*; for being is precisely this abstract relation-to-self. Being requires no further derivation, as though it belonged to the abstract product of definition only because it is taken from sensuous intuition or elsewhere, and in so far as it is pointed out to us. This pointing out and derivation is a matter of *mediation*, which is more than a mere beginning, and is a mediation of a kind that does not belong to a comprehension by means of thinking, but is the elevation of ordinary thinking, of the empirical and ratiocinative consciousness, to the standpoint of thought. According to the current opposition of thought or concept and being it is regarded as an important truth that no being belongs as yet to the former, taken on its own, and that the latter has a ground of its own that is independent of thought. But the simple determination of *being* is in itself so meagre that, if only for that reason, there is no need to make much fuss about it; the universal is immediately itself this immediate, since as abstract it also is merely the abstract relation-to-self, which is being. As a matter of fact, the demand that being should be exhibited for us to see has a further, inner meaning involving more than this abstract determination; what is meant by it is in general the demand for the *realization of the Notion*, which realization does not lie in the *beginn'ng* itself, but is rather the goal and the

task of the entire further development of cognition. Further, since the *content* of the beginning is supposed to be justified and authenticated as something true or correct by its being pointed out in inner or outer perception, it is no longer the *form* of universality as such that is meant, but its *determinateness*, of which we shall need to speak presently. The authentication of the *determinate content* with which the beginning is made seems to lie *behind* it; but in fact it is to be considered as an advance, that is, if it belongs to philosophical [*begreifenden*] cognition. Hence the beginning has for the method no other determinate

829

ness than that of being simple and universal; this is itself the *determinateness* by reason of which it is deficient. Universality is the pure simple Notion, and the method, as consciousness of the Notion, knows that universality is only a moment and that in it the Notion is not yet determined in and for itself. But with this consciousness that would carry the beginning further only for the sake of the method, the method would be a formal affair, something posited in external reflection. Since however it is the objective immanent form, the immediate of the beginning must be *in its own self* deficient and endowed with the *urge* to carry itself further. But in the absolute method the universal has the value not of a mere abstraction but of the objective universal, that is, the universal that is *in itself* the *concrete totality*, though that totality is not yet *posited*, is not yet *for itself*. Even the abstract universal as such, considered in its Notion, that is in its truth, is not merely the *simple*, but as *abstract* is already *posited* as infected with a *negation*. For this reason too *there is* nothing, whether in *actuality* or in *thought*, that is as simple and as abstract as is commonly imagined. A simple thing of this kind is a mere *presumption* that has its ground solely in the unconsciousness of what is actually present. Above, that with which the beginning is made was determined as the immediate; the *immediacy of the universal* is the same thing that is here expressed as the *in-itself* that is without a *being-for-self*. Hence it may indeed be said that every beginning must be made *with the absolute*, just as all advance is merely the exposition of it, in so far as its *in-itself* is the Notion. But because the absolute is at first only *in itself* it equally is *not* the absolute nor the posited Notion, and also not the Idea; for what characterizes these is precisely the fact that in them the *in-itself* is only an abstract, one-sided moment. Hence the advance is not a kind of *superfluity*; this it would be if that with which the beginning is made were in truth already the absolute; the advance consists rather in the universal determining itself and being *for itself* the universal, that is, equally an individual and a subject. Only in its consummation is it the absolute.

It is to be recalled that the beginning, which is *in itself* a concrete totality, may as beginning also be *free* and its immediacy have the determination of an *external existence*; the *germ of the living being* and the *subjective end* in general have proved themselves to be such beginnings and therefore both are themselves *urges*. The

non-spiritual and inanimate, on the contrary, are the Notion only as *real possibility*; *cause* is the highest stage in which the concrete Notion, as a beginning in the sphere of necessity has an immediate existence; but it is not yet a subject that maintains itself as such even in its actual realization. The *sun*, for example, and in general all inanimate things, are determinate concrete existences in which real possibility remains an *inner* totality and the moments of the totality are not *posited* in subjective form in them and, in so far as they realize themselves, attain an existence by means of *other* corporeal individuals.

2. The concrete totality which makes the beginning contains as such within itself the beginning of the advance and development. As concrete, it is *differentiated within itself*; but by reason of its *first immediacy* the first differentiated determinations are in the first instance merely a *diversity*. The immediate, however, as selfrelated universality, as subject, is also the *unity* of these diverse determinations. This reflection is the first stage of the movement onwards-the emergence of *real difference*, *judgement*, the *process of determining* in general. The essential point is that the absolute method finds and cognizes the *determination* of the universal within the latter itself. The procedure of the finite cognition of the understanding here is to take up again, equally externally, what it has left out in its creation of the universal by a process of abstraction. The absolute method, on the contrary, does not behave like external reflection but takes the determinate element from its own subject matter, since it is itself that subject matter's immanent principle and soul. This is what Plato demanded of cognition, that it should *consider things in and for themselves*, that is, should consider them partly in their universality, but also that it should not stray away from them catching at circumstances, examples and comparisons, but should keep before it solely the things themselves and bring before consciousness what is immanent in them. The method of absolute cognition is to this extent *analytic*. That it finds the further determination of its initial universal simply and solely in that universal, is the absolute objectivity of the Notion, of which objectivity the method is the certainty. But the method is no less *synthetic*, since its subject matter, determined immediately as a *simple universal*, by virtue of the determinateness which it possesses in its very immediacy and universality, exhibits itself as an other. This relation of differentiated elements which the

subject matter thus is within itself, is however no longer the same thing as is meant by synthesis in finite cognition; the mere fact of the subject matter's no less analytic determination in general, that the relation is relation within the *Notion*, completely distinguishes it from the latter synthesis.

This is no less synthetic than analytic moment of the *judgement*, by which the universal of the beginning of its own accord determines itself as the *other of itself*, is to be named the *dialectical* moment. *Dialectic* is one of those ancient sciences that have been most misunderstood in the metaphysics of the moderns, as well as by popular philosophy in general, ancient and modern alike. Diogenes Laertius says of Plato that, just as Thales was the founder of natural philosophy and Socrates of moral philosophy, so Plato was the founder of the third science pertaining to philosophy, namely, *dialectic*-a service which the ancient world esteemed his highest, but which often remains quite overlooked by those who have most to say about him. Dialectic has often been regarded as an *art*, as though it rested on a subjective *talent* and did not belong to the objectivity of the Notion. The shape it takes and the result it reaches in Rantian philosophy have already been pointed out in the specific examples of the Rantian view of it. It must be regarded as a step of infinite importance that dialectic is once more recognized as necessary to reason, although the result to be drawn from it must be the opposite of that arrived at by Rant. Besides the fact that dialectic is generally regarded as contingent, it usually takes the following more precise form. It is shown that there belongs to some subject matter or other, for example the world, motion, point, and so on, some determination or other, for example (taking the objects in the order named), finitude in space or time, presence in *this* place, absolute negation of space; but further, that with equal necessity the opposite determination also belongs to the subject matter, for example infinity in space and time, non-presence in this place, relation to space and so spatiality. The older Eleatic school directed its dialectic chiefly against motion, Plato frequently against the general ideas and notions of his time, especially those of the Sophists, but also against the pure categories and the determinations of reflection; the more cultivated scepticism of a later period extended it not only to the immediate so-called facts of consciousness and maxims of common life, but also to all the notions of

832

science. Now the conclusion drawn from dialectic of this kind is in general the *contradiction* and *nullity* of the assertions made. But this conclusion can be drawn in either of two senses--either in the objective sense, that the *subject matter* which in such a manner contradicts itself cancels itself out and is null and void-this was, for example, the conclusion of the Eleatics, according to which *truth* was denied, for example, to the world, to motion, to the point; or in the subjective sense, that *cognition is defective*. One way of understanding the latter sense of the conclusion is that it is only this dialectic that imposes on us the trick of an illusion. This is the common view of so-called sound common sense which takes its stand on the evidence of the senses and on *customary conceptions and judgements*. Sometimes it takes this dialectic lightly, as when Diogenes the cynic exposes the hollowness of the dialectic of motion by silently walking up and down; but often it flies into a passion, seeing it in perhaps a piece of sheer foolery, or,

when morally important objects are concerned, an outrage that tries to unsettle what is essentially established and teaches how to supply wickedness with grounds. This is the view expressed in the Socratic dialectic against that of the Sophists, and this is the indignation which, turned in the opposite direction, cost even Socrates his life. The vulgar refutation that opposes to thinking, as did Diogenes, *sensuous consciousness* and imagines that in the latter it possesses the truth, must be left to itself; but in so far as dialectic abrogates moral determinations, we must have confidence in reason that it will know how to restore them again, but restore them in their truth and in the consciousness of their right, though also of their limitations. Or again, the conclusion of subjective nullity may mean that it does not affect dialectic itself, but rather the cognition against which it is directed, and in the view of scepticism and likewise of the Kantian philosophy, *cognition in general*.

The fundamental prejudice in this matter is that dialectic has *only a negative result*, a point which will presently be more precisely defined. First of all as regards the above-mentioned *form* in which dialectic is usually presented, it is to be observed that according to that form the dialectic and its result affect the *subject matter* under consideration or else subjective *cognition*, and declare either the latter or the subject matter to be null and void, while on the other hand the *determinations* exhibited in the subject

833

matter as in a *third* thing receive no attention and are presupposed as valid on their own account. It is an infinite merit of the Kantian philosophy to have drawn attention to this uncritical procedure and by so doing to have given the impetus to the restoration of logic and dialectic in the sense of the examination of the *determinations of thought in and for themselves*. The subject matter, kept apart from thinking and the Notion, is an image or even a name; it is in the determinations of thought and the Notion that it *is* what it *is*. Therefore these determinations are in fact the sole thing that *matters*; they are the true subject matter and content of reason, and anything else that one understands by subject matter and content in distinction from them has value only through them and in them. It must not therefore be considered the fault of a subject matter or of cognition that these determinations, through their constitution and an external connexion, show themselves dialectical. On that assumption, the subject matter or the cognition is

represented as a subject into which the *determinations* in the form of predicates, properties, self-subsistent universals, are introduced in such a manner that, fixed and correct as they are by themselves, they are brought into dialectical relationships and contradiction only by extraneous and contingent connexion in and by a third thing. This kind of external and fixed subject of imagination and

understanding and these abstract determinations, far from meriting the status of *ultimates*, of secure and permanent substrates, are rather to be regarded as themselves immediate, as

just that kind of presupposed and initial immediate that, as was shown above, must in its own essential nature [*an und fur sich selbst*] submit to dialectic, because it is to be taken as *in itself* the Notion. Thus all the oppositions that are assumed as fixed, as for example finite and infinite, individual and universal, are not in contradiction through, say, an external connection; on the contrary, as an examination of their nature has shown, they are in and for themselves a transition; the synthesis and the subject in which they appear is the product of their Notion's own reflection. If a consideration that ignores the Notion stops short at their external relationship, isolates them and leaves them as fixed presuppositions, it is the Notion, on the contrary, that keeps them steadily in view, moves them as their soul and brings out their dialectic.

Now this is the very standpoint indicated above from which a universal *first, considered in and for itself*, shows itself to be the

834

other of itself. Taken quite generally, this determination can be taken to mean that what is at first *immediate* now appears as *mediated, related* to an other, or that the universal appears as a particular. Hence the second term that has thereby come into being is the *negative* of the first, and if we anticipate the subsequent progress, the *first negative*. The immediate, from this negative side, has been *extinguished* in the other, but the other is essentially not the *empty negative*, the *nothing*, that is taken to be the usual result of dialectic; rather is it the *other of the first*, the *negative of the immediate*; it is therefore determined as the *mediated-contains* in general the *determination of the first* within itself. Consequently the first is essentially *preserved* and *retained* even in the other. To hold fast to the positive in *its* negative, in the content of the presupposition, in the result, this is the most important feature in rational cognition; at the same time only the simplest reflection is needed to convince one of the absolute truth and necessity of this requirement and so far as *examples* of the proof of this are concerned, the whole of logic consists of such. Accordingly, what we now have before us is the *mediated*, which to begin with, or, if it is likewise taken immediately, is also a *simple* determination; for as the first has been extinguished in it, only the second is present. Now since the first also is *contained* in the second, and the latter is the truth of the former, this unity can be expressed as a proposition in which the immediate is put as subject, and the mediated as its predicate; for example, *the finite is infinite, one is many, the individual is the universal*. However, the inadequate form of such propositions is at once obvious. In treating of the *judgement* it has been shown that its form in general, and most of all the immediate form of the *positive* judgement, is incapable of holding within its grasp speculative determinations and truth. The direct supplement to it, the *negative* judgement, would at least have to be added as well. In the judgement the first, as subject, has the illusory show of a self-dependent subsistence, whereas it is sublated in its predicate as in its other; this negation is indeed contained in the content of the above propositions, but their positive form

contradicts the content; consequently what is contained in them is not posited-which would be precisely the purpose of employing a proposition.

The second determination, the *negative or mediated*, is at the same time also the *mediating* determination. It may be taken in

835

the first instance as a simple determination, but in its truth it is a *relation or relationship*; for it is the negative, *but the negative of the positive*, and includes the positive within itself. It is therefore the other, but not the other of something to which it is indifferent in that case it would not be an other, nor a relation or relationship -rather it is the *other in its own self*, the *other of an other* ; therefore it includes *its* own other within it and is consequently *as contradiction*, the *posited dialectic of itself*. Because the first or the immediate is *implicitly* the Notion, and consequently is also only *implicitly* the negative, the dialectical moment with it consists in positing in it the *difference* that it *implicitly* contains. The second, on the contrary, is itself the *determinate* moment, the *difference or relationship*; therefore with it the dialectical moment consists in positing the *unity* that is contained in it. If then the negative, the determinate, relationship, judgement, and all the determinations falling under this second moment do not at once appear on their own account as contradiction and as dialectical, this is solely the fault of a thinking that does not bring its thoughts together. For the material, the *opposed* determinations in *one relation*, is already *posited* and at hand for thought. But formal thinking makes identity its law, and allows the contradictory content before it to sink into the sphere of ordinary conception, into space and time, in which the contradictories are held *asunder* in juxtaposition and temporal succession and so come before consciousness without reciprocal contact. On this point, formal thinking lays down for its principle that contradiction is unthinkable; but as a matter of fact the thinking of contradiction is the essential moment of the Notion. Formal thinking does in fact think contradiction, only it at once looks away from it, and in saying that it is unthinkable it merely passes over from it into abstract negation.

Now the negativity just considered constitutes the *turning point* of the movement of the Notion. It is the *simple point of the negative relation* to self, the innermost source of all activity, of all animate and spiritual self-movement, the dialectical soul that everything true possesses and through which alone it is true; for on this subjectivity alone rests the sublation of the opposition between Notion and reality, and the unity that is truth. The *second* negative, the negative of the negative, at which we have arrived, is this sublation of the contradiction, but just as little as the contradiction is it an *act of external reflection*, but rather the *innermost, most*

836

objective moment of life and spirit, through which a *subject*, a *person*, a *free being*, exists. The *relation of the negative to itself* is to be regarded as the *second premiss* of the whole syllogism. If the terms *analytic* and *synthetic* are employed as opposites, the *first premiss* may be regarded as the *analytic moment*, for in it the immediate stands in *immediate* relationship to its other and therefore *passes over*, or rather has passed over, into it—although this relation, as already remarked, is also synthetic, precisely because that into which it passes over is its *other*. The second premiss here under consideration may be defined as *synthetic*, since it is the relation of the *differentiated term as such to the term from which it is differentiated*. Just as the first premiss is the moment of *universality and communication*, so the second is determined by *individuality*, which in its relation to its other is primarily exclusive, for itself, and different. The negative appears as the *mediating* element, since it includes within it itself and the immediate whose negation it is. So far as these two determinations are taken in some relationship or other as externally related, the negative is only the *formal* mediating element; but as absolute negativity the negative moment of absolute mediation is the unity which is subjectivity and soul. In this turning point of the method, the course of cognition at the same time returns into itself. As self-sublating contradiction this negativity is the *restoration* of the *first immediacy*, of simple universality; for the other of the other, the negative of the negative, is immediately the *positive*, the *identical*, the *universal*. If one insists on *counting*, this *second* immediate is, in the course of the method as a whole, the *third* term to the first immediate and the mediated. It is also, however, the third term to the first or formal negative and to absolute negativity or the second negative; now as the first negative is already the second term, the term reckoned as *third* can also be reckoned as *fourth*, and instead of a *triplicity*, the abstract form may be taken as a *quadruplicity*; in this way, the negative or the difference is counted as a *duality*. The third or fourth is in general the unity of the first and second moments, of the immediate and the mediated. That it is this *unity*, as also that the whole form of the method is a *triplicity*, is, it is true, merely the superficial external side of the mode of cognition; but to have demonstrated even this, and that too in a more specific application—for it is well known that the abstract number form itself was

837

advanced at quite an early period, but, in the absence of the Notion, without result—must also be regarded as an infinite merit of the Kantian philosophy. The *syllogism*, which is also threefold, has always been recognized as the universal form of reason; but for one thing it counted generally for a quite external form that did not determine the nature of the content, and for another thing, since it progresses in the formal sense merely in the understanding's determination of *identity*, it lacks the essential *dialectical* moment of *negativity*; yet this moment enters into the triplicity of determinations because the third is the unity of the first two, and these, since they are different, can be in the unity only as

sublated determinations. Formalism has, it is true, also taken possession of triplicity and adhered to its empty *schema*; the shallow ineptitude and barrenness of modern philosophic *construction* so-called, that consists in nothing but fastening this schema on to everything without Notion and immanent determination and employing it for an external arrangement, has made the said form tedious and given it a bad name. Yet the triteness of this use of it cannot detract from its inner worth and we must always value highly the discovery of the shape of the rational, even though it was at first uncomprehended.

Now more precisely the *third* is the immediate, but the immediate *resulting from sublation of mediation*, the simple resulting from *sublation of difference*, the positive resulting from sublation of the negative, the Notion that has realized itself by means of its otherness and by the sublation of this reality has become united with itself, and has restored its absolute reality, its *simple* relation to itself. This *result* is therefore the *truth*. It is *equally* immediacy *and* mediation; but such forms of judgement as: the third *is* immediacy and mediation, or: *it is the unity* of them, are not capable of grasping it; for it is not a quiescent third, but, precisely as this unity, is self-mediating movement and activity. As that with which we began was the *universal*, so the result is the *individual*, the *concrete*, the *subject*; what the former is *in itself*, the latter is now *equally for itself*, the universal is *posited* in the subject. The first two moments of the triplicity are *abstract*, untrue moments which for that very reason are dialectical, and through this their negativity make themselves into the subject. The Notion itself is *for us*, in the first instance, *alike* the universal that is in itself, *and* the negative that is for itself, *and* also the third, that which is both

838

in and for itself, the *universal* that runs through all the moments of the syllogism; but the third is the conclusion, in which the Notion through its negativity is mediated with itself and thereby posited *for itself* as the *universal* and the *identity of its moments*.

Now this result, as the whole that has withdrawn into and is *identical* with itself, has given itself again the form of *immediacy*. Hence it is now itself the same thing as the *starting-point* had determined itself to be. As simple self-relation it is a universal, and in this universality, the *negativity* that constituted its dialectic and mediation has also collapsed into *simple determinateness* which can again be a beginning. It may seem at first sight that this cognition of the result is an analysis of it and therefore must again dissect these determinations and the process by which it has come into being and been examined. But if the treatment of the subject matter is actually carried out in this analytic manner, it belongs to that stage of the Idea considered above, to the cognition of enquiry, which merely states of its subject matter what *is*, but not the necessity of its concrete identity and the Notion of it. But though the method of truth which comprehends the subject matter is, as we have shown, itself analytic, for it remains entirely within the

Notion, yet it is equally synthetic, for through the Notion the subject matter is determined dialectically and as an other. On the new foundation constituted by the result as the fresh subject matter, the method remains the same as with the previous subject matter. The difference is concerned solely with the relationship of the foundation as such; true, it is now likewise a foundation, but its immediacy is only a *form*, since it was a result as well ; hence its determinateness as content is no longer something merely picked up, but something *deduced* and *proved*.

It is here that the *content* of cognition as such first enters into the circle of consideration, since, as deduced, it now belongs to the method. The method itself by means of this moment expands itself into a *system*. At first the beginning had to be, for the method, wholly indeterminate in respect of content; to this extent it appears as the merely formal soul, for and by which the beginning was determined simply and solely in regard to its *form*, namely, as the immediate and the universal. Through the movement we have indicated, the subject matter has obtained for itself a *determinateness* that is a *content*, because the negativity that has withdrawn into simplicity is the sublated form, and as simple determinateness

839

stands over against its development, and first of all over against its very opposition to universality.

Now as this determinateness is the proximate truth of the indeterminate beginning, it condemns the latter as something imperfect, as well as the method itself that, in starting from that beginning, was merely formal. This can be expressed as the now specific demand that the beginning, since it is itself a determinate relatively to the determinateness of the result, shall be taken not as an immediate but as something mediated and deduced. This may appear as the demand for an infinite *retrogression* in proof and deduction; just as from the fresh beginning that has been obtained, a result likewise emerges from the method in its course, so that the advance equally rolls *onwards* to infinity.

It has been shown a number of times that the infinite progress as such belongs to reflection that is without the Notion; the absolute method, which has the Notion for its soul and content, cannot lead into that. At first sight, even such beginnings as *being*, *essence*, *universality*, seem to be of such a kind as to possess the complete universality and absence of content demanded for a wholly formal beginning, as it is supposed to be, and therefore, as absolutely first beginnings, demand and admit of no further regress. As they are pure relations to self, immediate and indeterminate, they do not of course possess within themselves the difference which in any other kind of beginning, is directly posited between the universality of its form and its content. But it is the very indeterminateness which the above logical beginnings have for their sole content that constitutes their determinateness; this consists, namely, in their negativity as sublated mediation; the

particularity of this gives even their indeterminateness a particularity by which *being*, *essence*, and *universality* are distinguished from one another. The determinateness then which belongs to them if they are taken by themselves is their *immediate determinateness*, just as much as the determinateness of any other kind of content, and therefore requires a deduction; for the method it is a matter of indifference whether the determinateness be taken as determinateness *ofform* or of *content*. That a content has been determined by the first of its results is not in fact for the method, the beginning of a new mode; the method remains neither more nor less formal than before. For since it is the absolute form, the Notion that knows itself and everything as Notion, there is no

840

content that could stand over against it and determine it to be a one-sided external form. Consequently, just as the absence of content in the above beginnings does not make them absolute beginnings, so too it is not the content as such that could lead the method into the infinite progress forwards or backwards. From one aspect, the *determinateness* which the method creates for itself in its result is the moment by means of which the method is self-mediation and converts *the immediate beginning into something mediated*. But conversely, it is through the determinateness that this mediation of the method runs its course; it returns *through a content* as through an apparent *other* of itself to its beginning in such a manner that not only does it restore that beginning-as a *determinate* beginning however-but the result is no less the sublated determinateness, and so too the restoration of the first immediacy in which it began. This it accomplishes as *a system of totality*. We have still to consider it in this determination.

We have shown that the determinateness which was a result is itself, by virtue of the form of simplicity into which it has withdrawn, a fresh beginning; as this beginning is distinguished from its predecessor precisely by that determinateness, cognition rolls onwards from content to content. First of all, this advance is determined as beginning from simple determinatenesses, the succeeding ones becoming ever *richer and more concrete*. For the result contains its beginning and its course has enriched it by a fresh determinateness. The *universal* constitutes the foundation ; the advance is therefore not to be taken as a *flowing* from one *other* to the next *other* .In the absolute method the Notion *maintains* itself in its otherness, the universal in its particularization, in judgement and reality; at each stage of its further determination it raises the entire mass of its preceding content, and by its dialectical advance it not only does not lose anything or leave anything behind, but carries along with it all it has gained, and inwardly enriches and consolidates itself.

This *expansion* may be regarded as the moment of content, and in the whole as the first premiss; the universal is *communicated* to the wealth of content, immediately maintained in it. But the relationship has also its second, negative or dialectical side. The enrichment proceeds in the *necessity* of the Notion, it is held by it, and each determination is a

reflection-into-self. Each new stage of *forthgoing*, that is, of *further determination*, is also a withdrawal

841

inwards, and the greater *extension* is equally a *higher intensity*. The richest is therefore the most concrete and most *subjective*, and that which withdraws itself into the simplest depth is the mightiest and most all-embracing. The highest, most concentrated point is the *pure personality* which, solely through the absolute dialectic which is its nature, no less *embraces and holds everything within itself*, because it makes itself the supremely free-the simplicity which is the first immediacy and universality.

It is in this manner that each step of the *advance* in the process of further determination, while getting further away from the indeterminate beginning is also *getting back nearer* to it, and that therefore, what at first sight may appear to be different, the retrogressive grounding of the beginning, and the *progressive further determining* of it, coincide and are the same. The method, which thus winds itself into a circle, cannot anticipate ie e l.;,;;!epment in time that the beginning is, as such, already something derived ; it is sufficient for the beginning in its immediacy that it is simple universality .In being that, it has its complete condition; and there is no need to deprecate the fact that it may only be accepted *provisionally* and *hypothetically*. Whatever objections to it might be raised-say, the limitations of human knowledge, the need to examine critically the instrument of cognition before starting to deal with the subject matter-are themselves *presuppositions*, which as *concrete determinations* involve the demand for their mediation and proof. Since therefore they possess no formal advantage over the *beginning* with the subject matter against which they protest, but on the contrary themselves require deduction on account of their more concrete content, their claim to prior consideration must be treated as an empty presumption. They have an untrue content, for they convert what we know to be finite and untrue into something incontestable and absolute, namely, a *limited* cognition determined as *form* and *instrument relatively to its content*; this untrue cognition is itself also the form, the process of seeking grounds, that is retrogressive. The method of truth, too, knows the beginning to be incomplete, because it is a beginning ; but at the same time it knows this incompleteness to be a necessity , because truth only comes to be itself through the negativity of immediacy. The impatience that insists *merely* on getting beyond the *determinate-whether* called beginning, object, the finite, or in whatever other form it be taken-and finding itself immediately

842

in the absolute, has before it as cognition nothing but the empty negative, the abstract infinite; in other words, a *presumed* absolute, that is presumed because it is not *posited*, not *grasped*; grasped it can only be through the *mediation* of cognition, of which the universal and immediate is a moment, but the truth itself resides only in the extended

course of the process and in the conclusion. To meet the subjective needs of unfamiliarity and its impatience, a survey of the *whole* may of course be given *in advance-by* a division for reflection which, after the manner of finite cognition, specifies the particular of the universal as something *already there* and to be awaited in the course of the science. Yet this affords us nothing more than a picture for *ordinary thinking* ; for the genuine transition from the universal to the particular and to the whole that is determined in and for itself, in which whole that first universal itself according to its true determination is again a moment, is alien to the above manner of division, and is alone the mediation of the science itself.

By virtue of the nature of the method just indicated, the science exhibits itself as a *circle* returning upon itself, the end being wound back into the beginning, the simple ground, by the mediation ; this circle is moreover a *circle of circles*, for each individual member as ensouled by the method is reflected into itself, so that in returning into the beginning it is at the same time the beginning of a new member. Links of this chain are the individual sciences [of logic, nature and spirit], each of which has an *antecedent* and a *successor-or*, expressed more accurately, *has* only the *antecedent* and *indicates* its *successor* in its conclusion.

Thus then logic, too, in the absolute Idea, has withdrawn into that same simple unity which its beginning is; the pure immediacy of being in which at first every determination appears to be extinguished or removed by abstraction, is the Idea that has reached through mediation, that is, through the sublation of mediation, a likeness correspondent to itself. The method is the pure Notion that relates itself only to itself; it is therefore the *simple self-relation* that is *being*. But now it is also *fulfilled being*, the *Notion that comprehends* itself, being as the *concrete* and also absolutely *intensive* totality. In conclusion, there remains only this to be said about this Idea, that in it, first, the *science of logic* has grasped its own Notion. In the sphere of *being*, the beginning of its *content*, its Notion appears as a knowing in a subjective reflection

843

external to that content. But in the Idea of absolute cognition the Notion has become the Idea's own content. The Idea is itself the pure Notion that has itself for subject matter and which, in running itself as subject matter through the totality of its determinations, develops itself into the whole of its reality, into the system of the science [of logic], and concludes by apprehending this process of comprehending itself, thereby superseding its standing as content and subject matter and cognizing the Notion of the science. Secondly, this Idea is still logical, it is enclosed within pure thought, and is the science only of the divine *Notion*. True, the systematic exposition is itself a realization of the Idea but confined within the same sphere. Because the pure Idea of cognition is so far confined within subjectivity, it is the *urge* to sublate this, and pure truth as the last result becomes

also the *beginning of another sphere and science*. It only remains here to indicate this transition.

The Idea, namely, in positing itself as absolute *unity* of the pure Notion and its reality and thus contracting itself into the immediacy of *being*, is the *totality* in this *form-nature*. But this determination has not *issued from a process of becoming*, nor is it a *transition*, as when above, the subjective Notion in its totality *becomes objectivity*, and the *subjective end becomes life*. On the contrary, the pure Idea in which the determinateness or reality of the Notion is itself raised into Notion, is an absolute *liberation* for which there is no longer any immediate determination that is not equally *posited* and itself Notion; in this freedom, therefore, no transition takes place; the simple being to which the Idea determines itself remains perfectly transparent to it and is the Notion that, in its determination, abides with itself. The passage is therefore to be understood here rather in this manner, that the Idea *freely releases* itself in its absolute self-assurance and inner poise. By reason of this freedom, the form of its determinateness is also utterly free-the *externality of space and time* existing absolutely on its own account without the moment of subjectivity. In so far as this externality presents itself only in the abstract immediacy of being and is apprehended from the standpoint of consciousness, it exists as mere objectivity and external life ; but in the Idea it remains essentially and actually [*an und fur sich*] the totality of the Notion, and science in the relationship to nature of divine cognition. But in this next resolve of the pure Idea to determine itself as external Idea, it thereby only posits for itself the mediation

844

out of which the Notion ascends as a free Existence that has withdrawn into itself from externality, that completes its selfliberation in the *science of spirit*, and that finds the supreme Notion of itself in the science of logic as the self-comprehending pure Notion.